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GROPING IN THE DARK



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A series of blasts at communally sensitive targets show terrorists are working to a game plan. Security agencies though seem clueless and have no plan to tackle the phenomena.

■ **By Amarnath K. Menon and Sandeep Unnithan**

The calm of the Friday afternoon on May 18 was shattered by an Improvised Explosive Device (IED) which ripped through the revered Mecca Masjid in Hyderabad killing nine persons, including four children and injuring 40 others. Five more people died in the police firing that followed the blasts. Hyderabad's bloodiest terror strike, the ninth such attack in the country in the past 22 months, was followed by the Gorakhpur blasts four days later. If terrorism were a business plan, then it is delivering a result every quarter. It has so far claimed over 500 lives and struck at places associated with the common man—from commuter trains in Mumbai to mosques in Hyderabad and Malegaon. It sees politicians mouthing cliched platitudes after each attack even as intelligence analysts warn of a disturbing complacency that has set in counter-terrorism operations after the resumption of peace talks with Pakistan.

They also indicate that it is a fallacy

to believe that there are rogue cells of the ISI at work operating beyond the pale of the Pakistani establishment. "Terror, carefully calibrated by the ISI, has now become an adjunct of Pakistan's foreign policy designed to keep India talking on Kashmir," said an intelligence official. The blast was the terrorists' newest game plan to target religious places and foment communal unrest. There are in fact striking similarities between the Hyderabad bombing and those in Malegaon and Jama Masjid in Delhi last year: choosing Friday congregations to create mass casualties and passing them off as the work of Hindu fundamentalists.

Security agencies suspect the latest bombing to be the handiwork of the Bangladesh-based Harkat-ul-Jihad-al-Islami (HUJI), an offshoot of the Pakistan-based HUJI, and its Hyderabad-born activist Mohammed Abdul Shahed aka Bilal. HUJI was also responsible for last year's blasts in Varanasi's Sankat Mochan temple. The HUJI struck first in October 2005, using a Bangladeshi suicide bomber to attack the city police commissioner's of-

BLASTS FROM THE PAST

GORAKHPUR

May 2007

TOLL: 10 injured

WHERE: Golghar locality

WHO DID IT: Unidentified terrorists



planted three bombs in tiffin boxes which were then tied to children's bicycles.

STATUS: Under investigation.

PANIPAT

February 2007

TOLL: 66 dead, 13 injured

WHERE: In the Samjhauta Express

WHO DID IT: Unidentified terrorists



planted two bombs, which had been kept in suitcases in two coaches.

STATUS: Unsolved.

Source: SOUTH ASIA TERRORISM PORTAL